

Intelligenza Artificiale

“Bayesian networks I”

Nicola Bellotto

A.A. 2025/2026

Lecture outline

- Motivation
- Product decomposition
- Conditional probability tables
- Inference by enumeration
- Examples

Slides partly based on Russell & Norvig instructors material <http://aima.cs.berkeley.edu/instructors.html>

Full joint distribution

- In theory, given the full joint distribution of a set of random variables, it is possible to answer **any query** by applying the rules of probability
- E.g., if we know

$$\mathbf{P}(\textit{Disease}, \textit{Symptom}_A, \textit{Symptom}_B) \equiv \mathbf{P}(D, A, B)$$

we can answer any query, such as

$$\mathbf{P}(D|A, B) = \frac{\mathbf{P}(D, A, B)}{\mathbf{P}(A, B)} = \frac{\mathbf{P}(D, A, B)}{\sum_D \mathbf{P}(D, A, B)}$$

$$\mathbf{P}(A|D) = \frac{\mathbf{P}(D, A)}{\mathbf{P}(D)} = \frac{\sum_B \mathbf{P}(D, A, B)}{\sum_{A, B} \mathbf{P}(D, A, B)}$$

Limitations

- However, the size of the joint distribution grows exponentially with the number of variables!
- E.g., assuming 3 boolean variables, we need $2^3 = 8$ values (actually 7: the last one is implicit because the sum must be 1)

<i>D</i>	<i>A</i>	<i>B</i>	<i>P(D, A, B)</i>
<i>true</i>	<i>t</i>	<i>t</i>	0.05
<i>t</i>	<i>t</i>	<i>f</i>	0.08
<i>t</i>	<i>f</i>	<i>t</i>	0.12
<i>t</i>	<i>f</i>	<i>f</i>	0.06
<i>false</i>	<i>t</i>	<i>t</i>	0.09
<i>f</i>	<i>t</i>	<i>f</i>	0.04
<i>f</i>	<i>f</i>	<i>t</i>	0.11
<i>f</i>	<i>f</i>	<i>f</i>	(0.45)

Problems with full joint distributions

- Obvious problems:
 - Worst-case complexity $O(a^n)$, where a is the largest arity (e.g. $a = 2$ for boolean) and n the number of variables
 - How to find the probabilities for $O(a^n)$ entries?
 - And where to store them?
- Fortunately in many cases it is possible to reduce large distributions into smaller ones thanks to **independence**



Factorising using independence

- Recall independence

$$P(a|b) = P(a) \text{ or } P(b|a) = P(b) \text{ or } P(a, b) = P(a)P(b)$$

- Factorisation** and independence reduce large joint distributions into smaller ones

- E.g. dental problems do not influence the weather (independent)

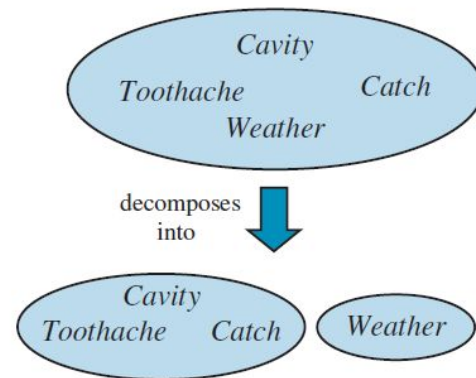
$$\mathbf{P(Toothache, Catch, Cavity, Weather)}$$

(16 values)

$$= \mathbf{P(Weather \mid \cancel{Toothache, Catch, Cavity})} \mathbf{P(Toothache, Catch, Cavity)}$$

$$= \mathbf{P(Weather)} \mathbf{P(Toothache, Catch, Cavity)}$$

(2+8=10 values)



Chain rule

- To simplify, let's start by decomposing the joint distribution in a product of conditional probabilities, a procedure called **chain rule**

$$\begin{aligned}P(x_1, \dots, x_n) &= P(x_n | x_{n-1}, \dots, x_1) P(x_{n-1}, \dots, x_1) \\&= P(x_n | x_{n-1}, \dots, x_1) P(x_{n-1} | x_{n-2}, \dots, x_1) P(x_{n-2}, \dots, x_1) \\&= \dots \\&= P(x_n | x_{n-1}, \dots, x_1) P(x_{n-1} | x_{n-2}, \dots, x_1) \dots P(x_2 | x_1) P(x_1) \\&= \prod_j P(x_j | x_1, \dots, x_{j-1})\end{aligned}$$

- For example

$$P(x_1, x_2, x_3) = P(x_3 | x_1, x_2) P(x_2 | x_1) P(x_1)$$

Product decomposition

- If X_j is independent from all but a subset of its predecessors (**parents**)

$$\prod_j \mathbf{P}(X_j | X_1, \dots, X_{j-1}) = \prod_j \mathbf{P}(X_j | Parents(X_j))$$

where

$$Parents(X_j) \subseteq \{X_1, \dots, X_{j-1}\}$$

then we can write the joint distribution as a product of conditional probabilities of all the variables given their parents (**product decomposition**)

$$\mathbf{P}(X_1, \dots, X_n) = \prod_j \mathbf{P}(X_j | Parents(X_j))$$

Product decomposition example

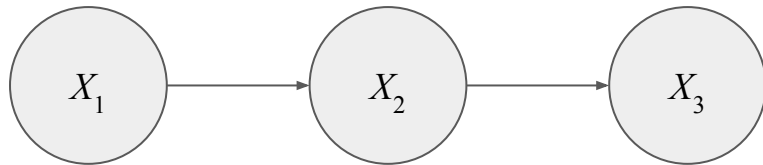
- For example

$$\mathbf{P}(X_1, X_2, X_3) = \mathbf{P}(X_3 | X_1, X_2) \mathbf{P}(X_2 | X_1) \mathbf{P}(X_1)$$

- If X_3 is (conditionally) independent of X_1 given X_2 , then

$$\mathbf{P}(X_1, X_2, X_3) = \mathbf{P}(X_3 | X_2) \mathbf{P}(X_2 | X_1) \mathbf{P}(X_1)$$

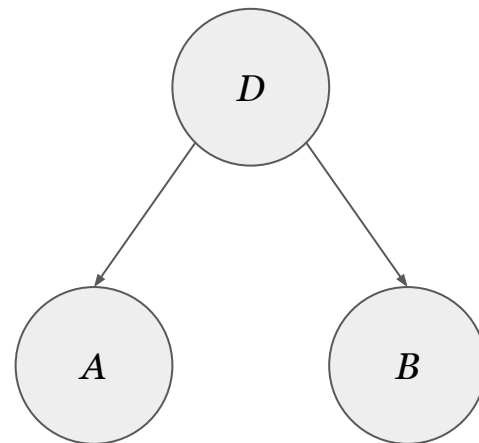
- In this case
 - X_2 is the parent of X_3
 - X_1 is the parent of X_2
 - X_1 has no parents



From full joint distributions to Bayesian networks

- In general, the joint distribution can be represented by a **Bayesian Network (BN)**
 - Also called **Belief Network**, **Probabilistic Graphical Model (PGM)**, **Directed Acyclic Graph (DAG)**

- The **nodes** are random variables and the **edges** are the dependencies between them

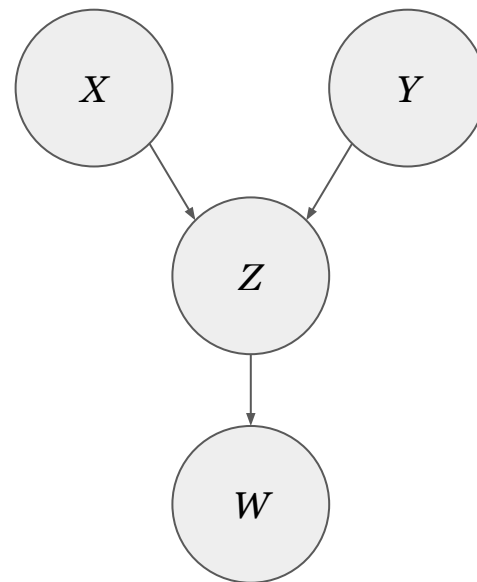


- For example
$$\mathbf{P}(A, B, D) = \mathbf{P}(A|Parents(A))\mathbf{P}(B|Parents(B))\mathbf{P}(D|Parents(D))$$
$$= \mathbf{P}(A|D)\mathbf{P}(B|D)\mathbf{P}(D)$$

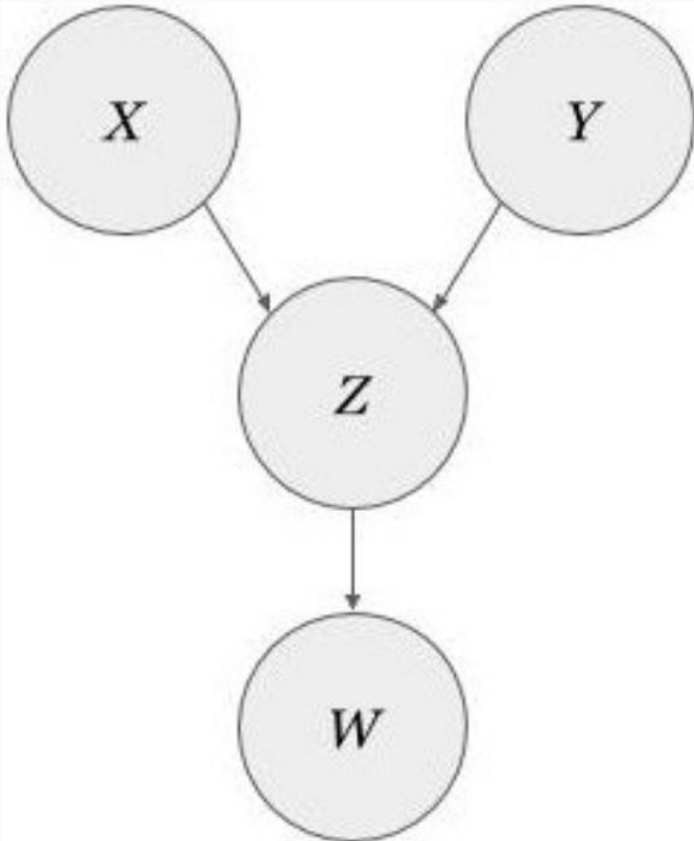
Example

- What is the joint distribution represented by this Bayesian Network?

$$\mathbf{P}(W, Z, X, Y) = ?$$



Joint Distribution of Bayesian Network



$$P(W)P(Z)P(X)P(Y)$$

0%

$$P(W|Z)P(Z|X,Y)P(X)P(Y)$$

0%

$$P(W,Z)P(Z,X)P(Z,Y)$$

0%

$$P(W|Z,X,Y)P(Z|X,Y)P(X)P(Y)$$

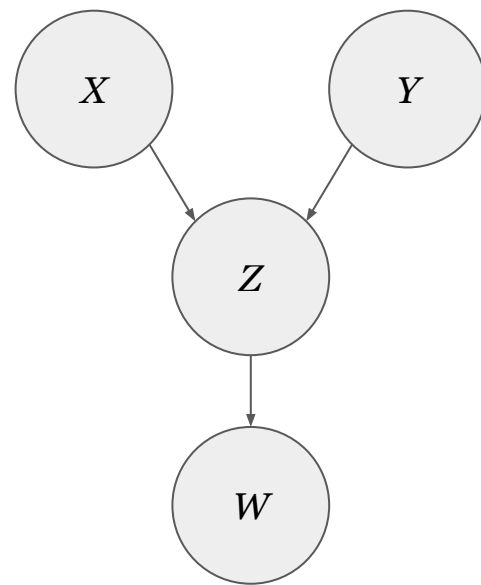
0%

None of the above

0%



Example

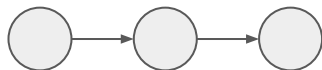


$$\begin{aligned}\mathbf{P}(W, Z, X, Y) \\ &= \mathbf{P}(W | Parents(W)) \mathbf{P}(Z | Parents(Z)) \mathbf{P}(X | Parents(X)) \mathbf{P}(Y | Parents(Y)) \\ &= \mathbf{P}(W | Z) \mathbf{P}(Z | X, Y) \mathbf{P}(X) \mathbf{P}(Y)\end{aligned}$$

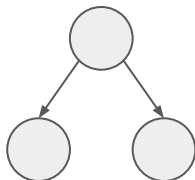
Bayesian network structures

- There are three main structures

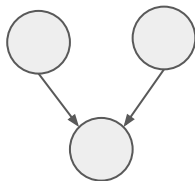
- **Chain**



- **Fork**



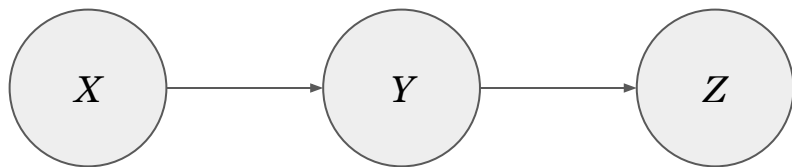
- **Collider**



Chain

- A **chain** or **head-to-tail** connection is a case in which

$$\mathbf{P}(X, Y, Z) = \mathbf{P}(Z|Y)\mathbf{P}(Y|X)\mathbf{P}(X)$$



- The two variables X and Z are conditionally independent given Y

$$\mathbf{P}(Z|X, Y) = \frac{\mathbf{P}(Z|Y)\mathbf{P}(Y|X)\mathbf{P}(X)}{\mathbf{P}(X, Y)} = \frac{\mathbf{P}(Z|Y)\mathbf{P}(X, Y)}{\mathbf{P}(X, Y)} = \mathbf{P}(Z|Y)$$

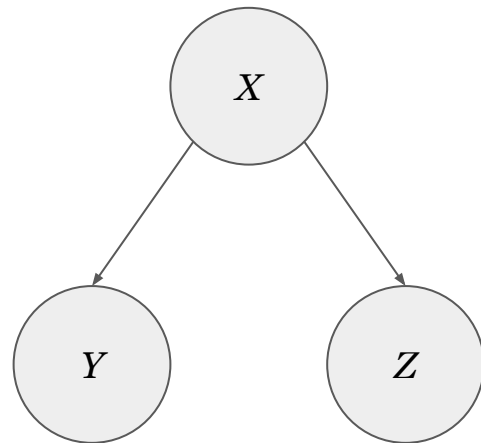
Fork

- A **fork** or **tail-to-tail** connection is a case in which

$$\mathbf{P}(X, Y, Z) = \mathbf{P}(Y|X)\mathbf{P}(Z|X)\mathbf{P}(X)$$

- The two variables Y and Z are conditionally independent given X

$$\mathbf{P}(Y, Z|X) = \frac{\mathbf{P}(Y|X)\mathbf{P}(Z|X)\mathbf{P}(X)}{\mathbf{P}(X)} = \mathbf{P}(Y|X)\mathbf{P}(Z|X)$$



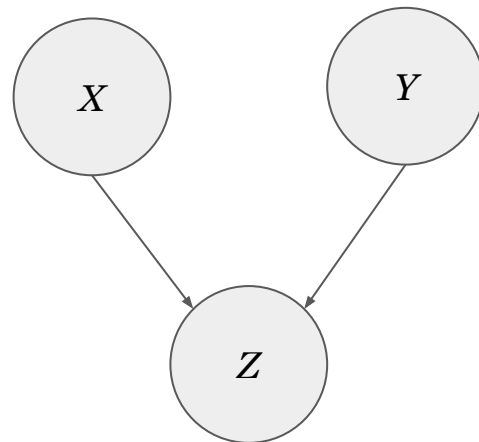
Collider

- A **collider** or **head-to-head** connection is a case in which

$$\mathbf{P}(X, Y, Z) = \mathbf{P}(Z|X, Y)\mathbf{P}(X)\mathbf{P}(Y)$$

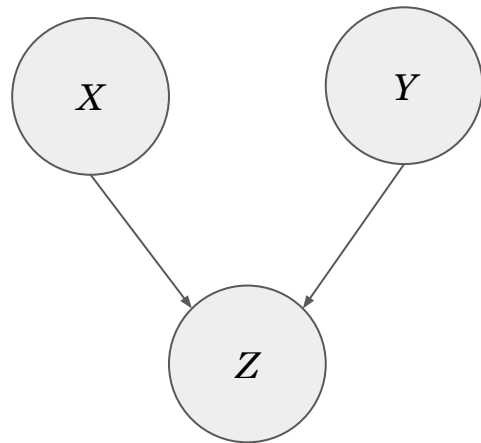
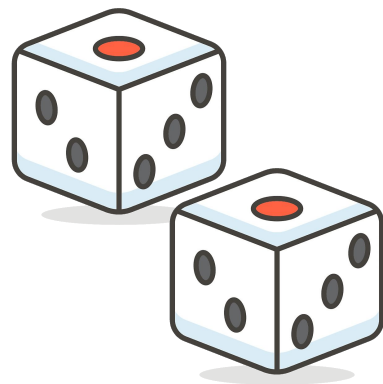
- The two variables X and Y are independent (**not** given Z)

$$\mathbf{P}(X, Y) = \sum_Z \mathbf{P}(Z|X, Y)\mathbf{P}(X)\mathbf{P}(Y) = \mathbf{P}(X)\mathbf{P}(Y)$$



Collider – example

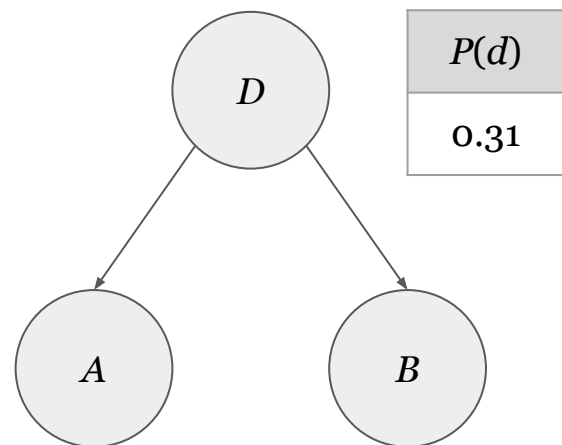
- X is the outcome of the first die
 - Y is the outcome of the second die
 - Z is the sum of the two outcomes
 - Suppose we know $Z = 7$ (it's “given”)
 - then if $X = 1$, it must be $Y = 6$...
 - and if $X = 2$, it must be $Y = 5$...
- $\Rightarrow Z$ creates a dependency between X and Y



Conditional probability tables

- In case of discrete variables, a **Conditional Probability Table (CPT)** is associated to each node
- If the BN in the figure represents the example of Slide 4, we can exploit the conditional independence of A and B given D to represent the full joint distribution with only **5** probabilities instead of the original **7** $\Rightarrow$ **$\sim 30\%$ less!**
- From these, we can derive all the probabilities of the joint distribution and therefore still answer any query
 - In the example, the tables do not need to specify $P(\neg d)$, $\mathbf{P}(\neg a|D)$, or $\mathbf{P}(\neg b|D)$ because they are implicit
 - $P(\neg d) = 1 - P(d)$
 - $\mathbf{P}(\neg a|D) = 1 - \mathbf{P}(a|D)$
 - $\mathbf{P}(\neg b|D) = 1 - \mathbf{P}(b|D)$

NOTE: lowercase letters are values, capital letters are variables, i.e. $\neg d$ means $D = \text{false}$



$P(d)$
0.31

D	$\mathbf{P}(a D)$
t	0.42
f	0.19

D	$\mathbf{P}(b D)$
t	0.55
f	0.29

Advantages of product decomposition

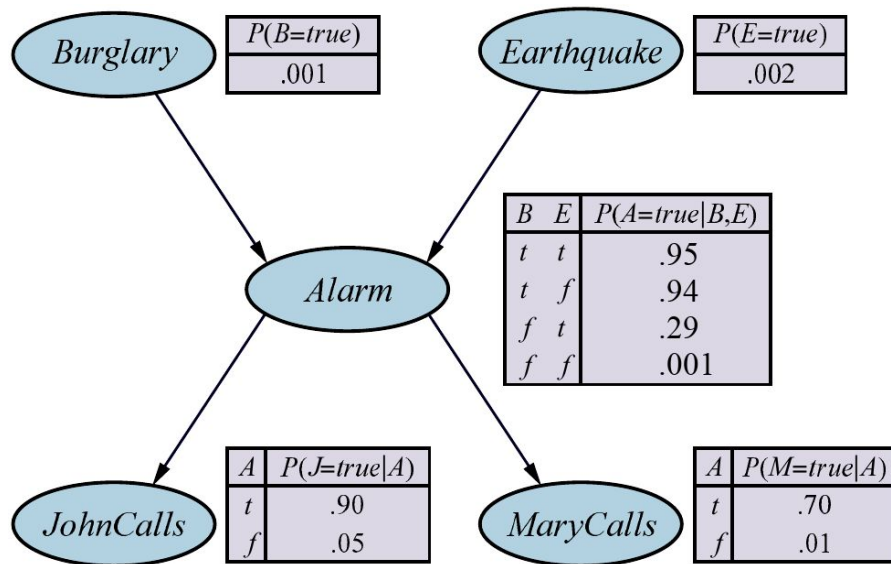
- Besides storage space, the product decomposition represented by a Bayesian Network improves also the accuracy of the estimation
- Example
 - Estimate the probabilities of $\mathbf{P}(A, B, D)$ from a dataset with only 25 samples
 - since there are 8 possible triplets, we have $25/8 \approx 3$ samples, in average, for each case (in reality some might have many samples, some none...)
 - If we estimate $\mathbf{P}(A|D)$, $\mathbf{P}(B|D)$, and $\mathbf{P}(D)$, instead, it's more likely to have enough samples
 - $25/4 \approx 6$ samples in average for $\mathbf{P}(A|D)$
 - $25/4 \approx 6$ samples in average for $\mathbf{P}(B|D)$
 - $25/2 \approx 12$ samples in average for $\mathbf{P}(D)$

these “simpler” probabilities are based on **more samples $\Rightarrow$ more accurate!**

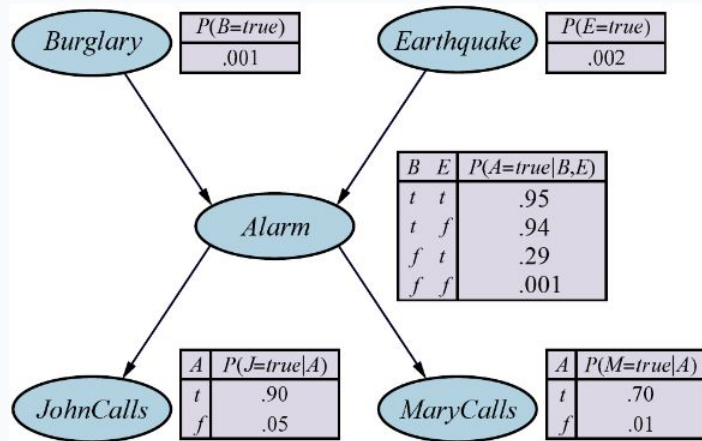
Example: burglary alarm (from Russell & Norvig's book)

- A home security alarm system can be triggered by a burglar or an earthquake
- Neighbors *John* and *Mary* should call the owner in case of alarm
- 5 CPTs (total size **10** instead of $2^5-1=31$)
- Example:

$$\begin{aligned} &P(j, m, a, \neg b, \neg e) \\ &= P(j|a)P(m|a)P(a|\neg b, \neg e)P(\neg b)P(\neg e) \\ &= 0.90 \times 0.70 \times 0.001 \times 0.999 \times 0.998 \approx 0.00063 \end{aligned}$$



Burglary Alarm: $P(j, \neg m, a, b, \neg e) = ?$



0.00000118

0

0.00059102

0

0.00000051

0

0.00025329

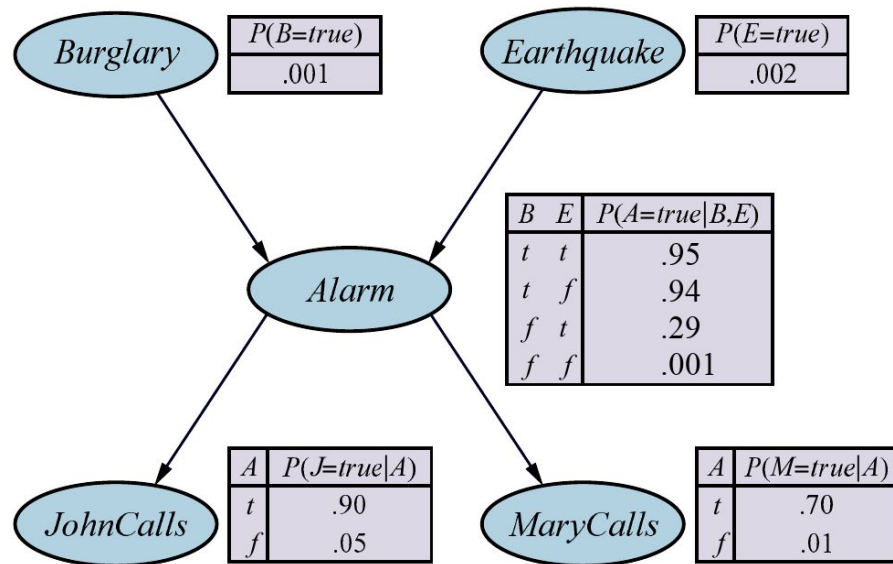
0

None of the above

0



Example: burglary alarm (from Russell & Norvig's book)



$$P(j, \neg m, a, b, \neg e)$$

$$= P(j|a)P(\neg m|a)P(a|b, \neg e)P(b)P(\neg e)$$

$$= 0.90 \times 0.30 \times 0.94 \times 0.001 \times 0.998 \approx 0.00025329$$

Network construction

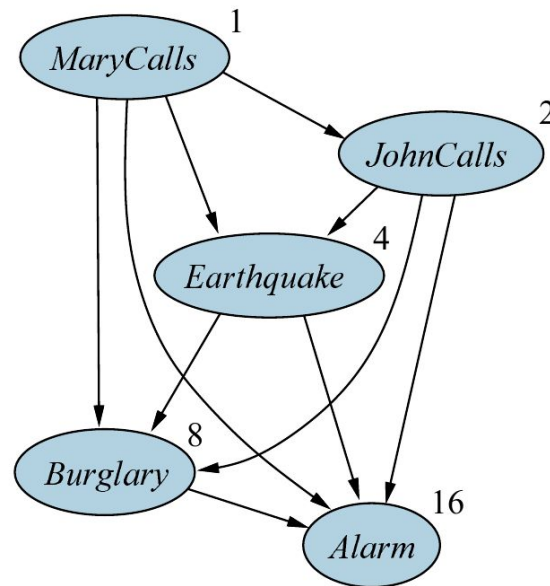
- Any node's ordering produces a correct Bayesian Network

- However, **causal models** – i.e. where the *Parents(X)* are the causes of *X* – are more efficient

- Example:

$$\mathbf{P}(A, B, E, J, M) = \mathbf{P}(A|B, E, J, M)\mathbf{P}(B|E, J, M)\mathbf{P}(E|J, M)\mathbf{P}(J|M)\mathbf{P}(M)$$

total size of CPTs = **31** >> 10



Inference by enumeration

- Let's start with a generic query to compute the probability of X given some evidence $\mathbf{e} = \{e_1, e_2, \dots, e_n\}$

$$\mathbf{P}(X|\mathbf{e}) = \frac{\mathbf{P}(X, \mathbf{e})}{P(\mathbf{e})} = \frac{\mathbf{P}(X, \mathbf{e})}{\sum_X P(X, \mathbf{e})}$$

- The denominator is the sum over all possible values of X , therefore

$$\mathbf{P}(X|\mathbf{e}) = \alpha \mathbf{P}(X, \mathbf{e}) \quad \alpha = \frac{1}{\sum_X P(X, \mathbf{e})}$$

where α is a **normalization** constant that guarantees the tot. probability is 1

Inference by enumeration

- With the joint distribution of a Bayesian Network, we can answer any query by marginalising (i.e. summing out) all the possible values $\mathbf{y} = \{y_1, y_2, \dots, y_k\}$ of the **hidden** (unobserved) variables that are not part of the query itself

$$\mathbf{P}(X|\mathbf{e}) = \alpha \mathbf{P}(X, \mathbf{e}) = \alpha \sum_{\mathbf{y}} \mathbf{P}(X, \mathbf{e}, \mathbf{y})$$

- For example, the probability of burglary given that both neighbors called is

$$P(b|j, m) = \alpha P(b, j, m) = \alpha \sum_e \sum_a P(b, j, m, e, a)$$

Example

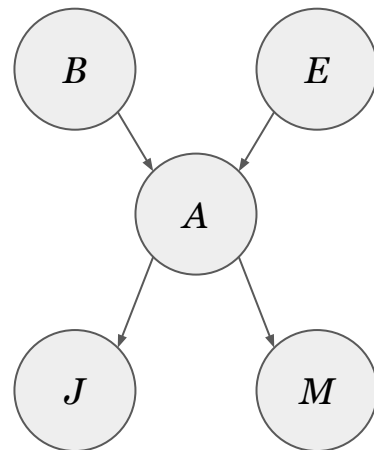
- Query

$$\mathbf{P}(B|j, m) = ?$$

- Solution

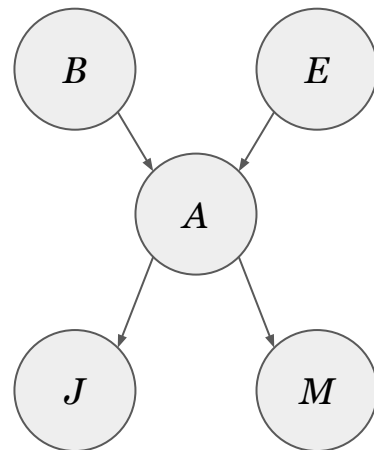
$$\begin{aligned}\mathbf{P}(B|j, m) &= \alpha \mathbf{P}(B, j, m) \\ &= \alpha \langle P(b, j, m), P(\neg b, j, m) \rangle\end{aligned}$$

- We can do inference by enumeration on the product decomposition of the BN to compute the probabilities $P(b, j, m)$ and $P(\neg b, j, m)$



Example

$$\begin{aligned} P(b, j, m) &= \sum_e \sum_a P(b, j, m, \overbrace{e, a}^{\text{not observed}}) \\ &= \sum_e \sum_a P(b)P(e)P(a|b, e)P(j|a)P(m|a) \\ &= P(b) \sum_e P(e) \sum_a P(a|b, e)P(j|a)P(m|a) \end{aligned}$$



- We repeat the same for $\neg b$
 - Finally, we normalize (with α) so that
- $$\alpha P(b, j, m) + \alpha P(\neg b, j, m) = P(b|j, m) + P(\neg b|j, m) = 1$$

Example

$$\begin{aligned}P(b, j, m) &= P(b) \sum_e P(e) \sum_a P(a|b, e) P(j|a) P(m|a) \\&= 0.001 \times [0.002 \times (0.95 \times 0.9 \times 0.7 + 0.05 \times 0.05 \times 0.01) + \\&\quad 0.998 \times (0.94 \times 0.9 \times 0.7 + 0.06 \times 0.05 \times 0.01)] \\&= 0.0005922\end{aligned}$$

$$\begin{aligned}P(\neg b, j, m) &= P(\neg b) \sum_e P(e) \sum_a P(a|\neg b, e) P(j|a) P(m|a) \\&= 0.999 \times [0.002 \times (0.29 \times 0.9 \times 0.7 + 0.71 \times 0.05 \times 0.01) + \\&\quad 0.998 \times (0.001 \times 0.9 \times 0.7 + 0.999 \times 0.05 \times 0.01)] \\&= 0.0014919\end{aligned}$$

Example

- The distribution of the query is therefore

$$\mathbf{P}(B|j, m) = \alpha \langle 0.0005922, 0.0014919 \rangle$$

$$\alpha = \frac{1}{0.0005922 + 0.0014919} \approx 479.823$$

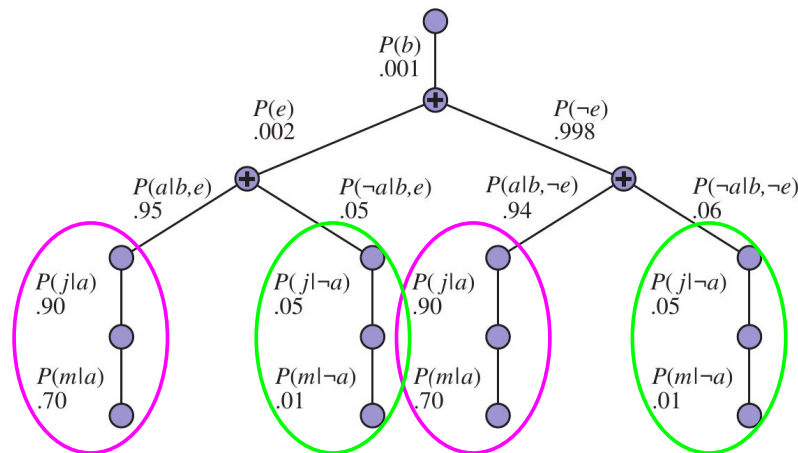
$$\mathbf{P}(B|j, m) = \langle 0.284, 0.716 \rangle$$

Example

- Inference by enumeration is a depth-first, left-to-right recursive calculation process

$$\begin{aligned}
 \text{e.g. } P(b, j, m) &= P(b) \sum_e P(e) \sum_a P(a|b, e) P(j|a) P(m|a) \\
 &= 0.001 \times [0.002 \times (0.95 \times \underline{0.9 \times 0.7} + 0.05 \times \underline{0.05 \times 0.01}) + \\
 &\quad 0.998 \times (0.94 \times \underline{0.9 \times 0.7} + 0.06 \times \underline{0.05 \times 0.01})]
 \end{aligned}$$

- However, some operations are repeated multiple times
- Possible improvement: save and reuse intermediate results (i.e. **variable elimination** algorithm)



Summary

- The **full joint probability distribution** specifies the probability of each complete assignment of values to random variables
- **Conditional independence** brought about by direct causal relationships in the domain allows the full joint distribution to be factored into smaller, conditional distributions
- **Bayesian networks** provide a natural representation for (causally induced) conditional independence
- **Topology + CPTs** = compact representation of joint distribution, generally easy for (non)experts to construct

Conclusions

- Suggested reading
 - Chapter 1, sec. 1.4 and 1.5.2 of Pearl et al.
 - Chapter 13, sec. 13.1-13.3 of Russell & Norvig
- Next lecture
Bayesian Networks II
- Questions?

